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Source: *Political Theory*, April 2016, Vol. 44, No. 2 (April 2016), pp. 240-264

Published by: Sage Publications, Inc.

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24768038>

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To Narrate and Denounce: Frederick Douglass and the Politics of Personal Narrative

Political Theory
2016, Vol. 44(2) 240–264
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DOI: 10.1177/0090591714549075
ptx.sagepub.com


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Abstract

What political problem can autobiography solve? This article examines the politics of Frederick Douglass's antebellum personal narratives: his 1845 slave narrative, the *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave*, and his 1855 autobiography, *My Bondage and My Freedom*, written at the opposite ends of Douglass's transition from the abolitionist politics of William Lloyd Garrison and Wendell Phillips to Douglass's defense of political action and the Constitution as anti-slavery. Placing the two texts alongside Douglass's distinction "to narrate wrongs" and "denouncing them," I argue that Douglass writes *My Bondage and My Freedom* as a mode of *denunciation*: an autobiographical critique of injustice that balances analysis of collective oppression with advocacy for communal emancipation. Whereas to narrate wrongs encouraged readers to judge Douglass's story alongside popular criteria of justice, to denounce wrongs is to implicate readers within the structures that create antebellum subjects on and off the plantation, by revealing the coercions and conditionings of society that make not simply slaves but slaveowners, sympathizers, and abolitionists. This article claims that autobiography is a distinct genre of political theory, one that challenges present relations between the individual and the collective by representing not simply its author but an expanded view of "the people."

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Keywords

Frederick Douglass, autobiography, democratic theory, literature, American political thought

“Tell your story, Frederick,” would whisper my then revered friend, William Lloyd Garrison, as I stepped upon the platform. I could not always obey, for I was now reading and thinking. New views of the subject were presented to my mind. It did not entirely satisfy me to narrate wrongs; I felt like denouncing them.

Frederick Douglass, *My Bondage and My Freedom*¹

What political problem can autobiography solve? Four years after escaping slavery in Maryland, Frederick Douglass wrote the 1845 *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave* in the genre of slave narrative, with the help of William Lloyd Garrison and Wendell Phillips. Over the next decade, it would sell thirty thousand copies in twenty-one editions, translated and sold in America and Europe.² One of these copies Douglass sent to his legal owner, challenging Thomas Auld to refute its representation of slavery; Auld defended himself in a southern newspaper.³ By the time Douglass wrote Auld another letter in 1848 (pledging “to make use of you as a weapon with which to assail the system of slavery”), Douglass had begun drifting from Garrison and Phillips.⁴ Their use of moral suasion and calls for disunion clashed with Douglass’s strengthening defense of political action and the U.S. Constitution as anti-slavery.⁵ In the period before 1855, the Compromise of 1850 and the Kansas-Nebraska Act would polarize national conversation, and Douglass would find new interlocutors in Gerrit Smith, James McCune Smith, Martin Delany, and others.⁶ This was a period in which Douglass vacillated between “hope and gloom,” David Blight notes, between his “American jubilee” and pessimism over national compromises and abolitionists’ lingering racism.⁷ Rather than abandon southern slaves and absolve northern citizens, Douglass wanted to refound the nation. To this effort, Douglass wrote his 1855 autobiography, *My Bondage and My Freedom*, which would soon sell twenty thousand copies there and abroad.⁸ Although *Bondage* is nearly triple the length of *Narrative*, little more than a tenth of the book recalls events past the end of the 1845 text. Compare this to Douglass’s third personal narrative, *Life and Times* of 1881 and 1892, a text twice the length of *Bondage* yet more than half dedicated to Douglass’s life after 1855.⁹ This second book did not simply capture more, but a different Douglass. Garrison disliked this new self-made man: he censured a positive review of the book, to which Douglass asked that Garrison point to “the offensive portions” of the book, such that readers “may read and judge for themselves.”¹⁰ Garrison did not respond.

Scholars often look to Douglass's narratives to capture what W.E.B. Du Bois called Douglass's "self-assertion"; political theory looks to what Eric Sundquist describes as the ex-slave's embodiment of non-dominated independence, at a time of uncertainty for the Revolution's legacy.¹¹ Recent political theory monographs on Douglass draw on his personal narratives to supplement letters or speeches with biography.¹² Other theorists treat Douglass's overcoming of the slavebreaker Edward Covey (a scene featured in all three narratives) as a model for self-authorization, as in Herbert Marcuse's letter to Angela Davis or recent studies of honor and dignity.¹³ Despite how frequently these personal narratives appear in scholarship on Douglass, no political theorist has asked what it might mean for either to be more than a story of self-making but a form of dissent, a response to the authorities that ground slavery or early abolitionist politics. This is true not only of work on Douglass but of political theory's general treatment of autobiography. Although scholars have read political theory through the novel, the jeremiad, and the pamphlet (among other genres), few political theory approaches to autobiography exist.¹⁴ Although scholars such as Robert Gooding-Williams have compellingly argued for the "declarations of independence" in *My Bondage and My Freedom*, what if we read each narrative as its own declaration?¹⁵

This article considers the political relevance of Douglass's personal narratives by drawing on his distinction "to narrate wrongs" and "denouncing them." Like scholars before, I read Douglass's first text as slave narrative, his second as autobiography.¹⁶ I argue that Douglass writes *My Bondage and My Freedom* as a mode of *denunciation*: an autobiographical critique of injustice that balances analysis of collective oppression with advocacy for communal emancipation. Although Douglass's first narrative recounts his enslavement and escape, abolitionist publication of slave narrative and "slavery on trial" rhetoric framed *Narrative* within a racial hierarchy of black testimony and white advocacy. *Narrative* critiqued slavery but not the racism that underwrote both the peculiar institution and abolitionists' lingering prejudice. Whereas to narrate wrongs encouraged readers to judge Douglass's story alongside popular criteria of justice, to denounce wrongs in *My Bondage and My Freedom* is to implicate readers within the structures that create antebellum subjects on and off the plantation, by revealing the coercions and conditionings of society that make not simply slaves but slaveowners, sympathizers, and abolitionists. Thus Douglass's self-making in *Bondage* fits his developing politics, one that rejected moral suasion or disunion and that looked to expansive conceptions of "the people," such as those marshalled in response to *Dred Scott v. Sandford* or Independence Day celebrations. If slavery were—as Orlando Patterson would say—Douglass's social death, his autobiography would be his and the people's rebirth.¹⁷

To lay out the politics of Douglass's narratives, it may be useful to place denunciation between what Melvin Rogers has recently distinguished as the "descriptive" and "aspirational" invocations of "the people," the former an account of the individuals that a constitution or institutions specifically represent, and the latter an emancipatory claim to a future, unbounded constituency.¹⁸ This highlights two sides of denunciation captured in the title *My Bondage and My Freedom*: Douglass provides both a systemic analysis of antebellum peoplehood and a series of practices that produce a new self and people. Denunciation answers Rogers's "How do you move the people so that they will embrace an expanded view of themselves?"¹⁹ Denunciation, through autobiography, hovers on a line between what the people were and who they can be. This may seem counterintuitive, given the genre's focus not on a people who will be but an individual who was. But Douglass's multiple narratives insist that the self-evident "I" of published experience is not a given. In the same way that Jason Frank emphasizes the self-evidence of the Declaration or the Preamble's "We" as a place of contested postrevolutionary representations, so too is personal narrative at the intersection of political, historical, and economic expressions of the people.²⁰ For Douglass, these contestations didn't only result in a "constituent moment," but a new autobiographical declaration of the author and the people.

Of course, denunciation is but one of many ways through which political thinkers have framed autobiography, a genre that can provide exemplary or representative life stories, ethical ways of living, records of struggle, and so on. The broader claim beyond this article is that autobiography is a distinct form of political theory: in Douglass's case, distinct from slave narrative. Although scholars did not consider autobiography a genre any more literary than historical marginalia till the 1960s, those writing on autobiography in the past few decades have stressed the fluidity of the genre: it either covers everything, as in the deconstructionist Paul de Man's claim that all texts may include an "autobiographical moment," or it is potentially exclusionary, as in Julie Rak's assertion that the genre privileges Western, white male subjects.²¹ As Irving Howe wrote in his 1957 *Politics and the Novel*, my goal is not to rigidly categorize autobiography, rather to explore its distinct relevance for democratic politics over other genres.²² In this article, I treat autobiography as published personal narrative for which the author has authority over the representation of his experience, a genre that emerges roughly at the end of the eighteenth century. Autobiography is unique in requiring its author's full authority over the use of experience, unlike the confession, biography, or slave narrative. I use "personal narrative" more capaciously to speak of related genres. In the conclusion, I will suggest several family resemblances for what might distinguish the politics of autobiography in American history.

The benefits of reading autobiography as political theory are at least two-fold. Although autobiography shares liberalism's inheritance of Enlightenment individualism, its reliance on the particular moves beyond American political thought's frequent impulse to situate figures like Douglass within trajectories of liberalism or republicanism. There's no question that Douglass promoted the language of natural rights, and many political theorists productively explore Douglass's political theory in this context.²³ But autobiography often recalls communal attachments or details foreign to a strictly liberal or republican tradition, putting figures like Douglass closer to those theorists who either complicate Douglass's place in liberalism or complicate liberalism through Douglass.²⁴ Douglass's autobiography privileges what Michael Hanchard describes as "the practice of reconfiguration," a mode of reading that does not simply rescue marginalized subjects but "aims to literally reconfigure the representation of the relationship between forms of black politics and a wider (national, regional, global) set of political, economic, and social realities."²⁵

Autobiography also responds to a bigger question in democratic theory, as to what democratic theory should give us. If democratic theory, following Sheldon Wolin's review of John Rawls's *Political Liberalism*, cannot be a "gift to the demos"—an abstract template for justice removed from the experience of injustice—then what should it look like?²⁶ Autobiography provides one suggestion, at least since Rousseau addressed his 1782 *Confessions* not to God but "to my kind."²⁷ In American history in particular, autobiography appeals not simply for Douglass but his inheritors Booker T. Washington and Du Bois, his antecedent Benjamin Franklin, and those with radical sympathies such as Henry Thoreau, Henry Adams, and Emma Goldman. Significant autobiographies appear at times when the relation between the individual and the state is in question, be that relation one of inheritance, imperialism, industrialization, education, immigration, or so on. These autobiographies portray not simply the author but the people not represented by political institutions or literary genres of the day. It is through autobiography, then, that many political thinkers have critiqued the polis not while standing above but within the demos.

The article lays out *Bondage* and denunciation in three sections: (1) I look at the relation between authority and experience in the slave narrative genre and Douglass's 1845 *Narrative*, both of which parallel Douglass's developing critiques of Garrison and others. (2) I read the preface to *Bondage* as reorienting the rhetorical strategy of "slavery on trial" from a claim of popular judgment to a renegotiation of the people. (3) In light of these two critiques, I portray *Bondage* as providing an account of slave-making that denounces others not as wrong-doers but as subjects of slavery as well.

Whereas to narrate wrongs is to try them against popular law or morality, to denounce wrongs implicates readers in the practice and product of self-examination that make up Douglass's autobiography. In addition to the emancipatory practices advocated within *My Bondage and My Freedom*, autobiography seeks to convert readers beyond the injustice that sponsored slavery and lingered even in abolitionist circles.

The Binding of Narrative

In the early nineteenth century, abolitionists published slave narratives as the public testimonies of slavery's survivors. Unlike autobiography, abolitionists and not authors authorized personal experience in the slave narrative: though focused on the life stories of narrators such as Charles Ball and Moses Roper, slave narratives treated authors as a means to illuminate and not interpret slavery.²⁸ In William Andrews's words, the genre made of the narrator "an eyewitness, not an I-witness."²⁹ Intended to reorient white readers' moral compasses, the slave narrative's political effectiveness hinged on its status as empirical proof. As a result, a common pro-slavery strategy was to question narratives' authenticity, although narrators did occasionally forge accounts. Shortly after publication, readers discovered the 1836 *Memoirs of Archy Moore* and the 1838 *Narrative of James Williams* to be fictional: the Massachusetts Anti-Slavery Society had distributed and defended the latter in *The Liberator*.³⁰ Although slave narratives were instrumental in swaying the national conversation on slavery as well as raising funds for abolitionist politics, this was a conversation predominantly among whites, the narrative's ex-slave author in the background.

The racial hierarchies borne in part by slavery lingered in abolitionist strategies to authenticate slave narratives. The black ex-slave related his experience in speech or writing, and the white abolitionist validated the story as ghostwriter, amanuensis, or by simply putting his name on it.³¹ Although white testimony occasionally required verification (such as the narratives and letters of Theodore Dwight Weld's 1839 *American Slavery As It Is*, a work that inspired Douglass's writings), here too other white citizens certified the evidence.³² Abolitionists not only warranted ex-slave experience: they interpreted it, in literature and in rhetoric. Jeannine DeLombard writes that the "slavery on trial" motif "portrayed slaveholders as perpetrators and defendants, slaves as victims and witnesses, white abolitionists as advocates for the slave, and the American reading public as a court of public opinion."³³ At the time, black testimony was inadmissible evidence in the American courts. This motif critiqued the laws protecting slavery and appealed to a culture of Jacksonian popular judgment.³⁴

We shouldn't mistake the emancipatory potential of slave narrative. As Houston Baker writes, the genre was the ex-slave's first chance to "seize the word": without a history of (literary) citizenship, his problem was "not to answer Crèvecoeur's question: 'What then is the American, this new man?'" but "the problem of being itself."³⁵ In addition to supporting abolitionist appeals, slave narrative accompanied the rise of literary societies among free blacks; in contemporary scholarship, the genre helped expand the literary canon to include writings past those of white men.³⁶ The genre nonetheless put its authors in an awkward political position. Although it encouraged white readers' sympathy, it reinforced inequality supposedly unique to slavery. As we'll see with Douglass, it also paralleled explicit racism that endured among abolitionists. Slave narrators suffered what feminist Kristie Dotson calls "an *epistemic exclusion*": "an infringement on the epistemic agency of knowers that reduces her or his ability to participate in a given epistemic community."³⁷ The effort to shift focus from the author to slavery and the abolitionist undercut the genre's potential self-authorization.

Written in the slave narrative tradition, Douglass's *Narrative* exemplifies this clash between author and abolitionist. Like most ex-slaves on the abolitionist circuit, Douglass regularly spoke from experience: "my friends," he welcomed an audience in 1841, "I have come to tell you something about slavery."³⁸ Douglass wrote *Narrative* in response to allegations that he was too articulate to have been a slave.³⁹ Even after its publication, Douglass continued to defend his account; when his owner's colleague A.C.C. Thompson indicted Douglass's book in a Delaware paper, Douglass responded by thanking him for proving the existence of the story's characters, pledging to publish the complaint with subsequent copies of *Narrative*.⁴⁰ Elements early in the text—what Philippe Lejeune calls the speech act of an "autobiographical pact"—establish Douglass's authenticity through appeal to Garrison and Phillips.⁴¹ The title page of *Narrative*—"WRITTEN BY HIMSELF"—authenticates Douglass as a lecturer, writer, and ex-slave, and the next page features a signed daguerreotype of the young narrator.⁴² In his preface, Garrison (also the book's editor) introduces Douglass by verifying his tale, their first meeting, and that Douglass wrote the story (*NF*, 3-10). The event of the two meetings is in fact Douglass's closing scene in *Narrative*. In the book's introduction, Phillips's letter also authorizes Douglass: he insists of him that "we have known you long, and can put the most entire confidence in your truth, candor, and sincerity" (12). Douglass may have written *Narrative* to verify his lectures, but white abolitionists verify his narrative.

Despite what prefaced Douglass's narrative both in politics and publication, its content provided what was a landmark story of resistance. A common abolitionist claim depicted slaveowners as hypocritical for their devout

Christianity.⁴³ Douglass framed *Narrative* as a conversion story, its protagonist turning to abolitionism while his masters grew only crueler in their conversion to Methodism. This characterization incited enough controversy that later editions included an appendix specifying Douglass's target as southern Christianity in particular (*NF*, 95). *Narrative* broke from slave narrative in Douglass's efforts to describe his independence: his first awareness of chattelhood in learning to read, his fight with Covey, his escape. But the text is at once solely focused on Douglass's life *and* on the institution of slavery, failing to explain slavery's broader consequences or how the two were connected. Unlike his expanded interpretation of the plantation in *Bondage*, early accounts of slavery in *Narrative* focus primarily on the system's injustices, with few passages attesting to Douglass's early awareness of his subjection. Though Douglass recounts his youthful beatings, his sleeping cold and with no bed, left out of these accounts is any sense of self-reflection till he first attempts to read (33). Again, *Narrative* would be the first of several narratives to push against trends in the genre: yet its limited self-portrayal reveals that Douglass had not yet incorporated into his analysis of slavery the critiques that would motivate his leaving Garrison.

Though reviews praised *Narrative*, they suggested work to be done in another personal narrative. Transcendentalist Margaret Fuller highlighted the text as "evidence" against racial prejudice, yet lamented Garrison and Phillips as unappealing to the people, in contrast with Douglass.⁴⁴ But the problem was greater. As Joan Scott writes of orthodox history, slave narrative's use of experience as evidence "reproduces rather than contests given ideological systems."⁴⁵ In reading *Narrative*, "we know that difference exists, but we don't understand it as relationally constituted."⁴⁶ In his 1849 review of slave narrative, Ephraim Peabody criticized Douglass for *Narrative*'s "violent and unqualified statements and . . . sweeping denunciations."⁴⁷ Having begun his transition from Garrison, Douglass clarified these denunciations in his *North Star*, writing there that "what slavery is to the slave, the slaveholder is to the slave; and the character of the slaveholder may be fairly inferred from his treatment of the slave."⁴⁸ This clarification—that a critique of the plantation was not moral but social or systemic—Douglass would weave into the self-analysis of his autobiography.

I've emphasized the political context of slave narrative, particularly its racial hierarchy and use of experience as evidence, to make a crucial point about Douglass's transition to *My Bondage and My Freedom*. If *Narrative* staged Douglass's break from slavery, then Douglass's autobiography emancipates its author from both slavery *and* Garrison's abolitionism. Toward the end of *Bondage*, Douglass criticizes the Garrisonian abolitionists for politics similar to the problems of slave narrative, thus returning that text to its

motivating concern. Three major disagreements stand out. First, abolitionists criticize Douglass when he begins his own newspaper upon returning from Britain in 1846, a paper to be run primarily by black Americans (*MB*, 387).⁴⁹ He defends the project for the same reasons he'll defend *Bondage* in its preface, that "the greatest hinderance to the adoption of abolition principles by the people of the United States, was the low estimate, everywhere in that country, placed upon the negro, as a man" (386). Garrisonians respond that Douglass is "better fitted to speak than write" (389–90). Second, Garrison's followers are unwilling to consider Douglass's developing pro-Constitution views, Douglass having come to see disunion as abandoning southern blacks: "Those who could not see any honest reasons for changing their views, as I had done, could not easily see any such reasons for my change" (392–93). Douglass describes the abolitionists much as he had slaveholders in *Narrative*: confronted by racism, wielding principles of justice, yet unable to convert. Finally, prejudice endures among abolitionists. Douglass recounts their stubbornness while lecturing, admitting that though the abolitionists resisted racism they "were not entirely free from it."

But what's most interesting in reading *My Bondage and My Freedom* as a response to *Narrative* is how the former employs the metaphor of writing to critique the early abolitionists. Even before Douglass's first narrative, a fairly well-known author had relied on metaphors of print for political identity: Benjamin Franklin. If autobiography staged what Michael Warner calls Franklin's "being-in-print," then Douglass's use of this metaphor further reveals his attempts to join the national conversation represented by autobiography.⁵⁰ Douglass ends *Narrative* with his first meeting Garrison, yet describes that lecture later in *Bondage* as Garrison "taking me as his text" (*MB*, 365). In another lecture, John Collins introduces Douglass as "a graduate from the peculiar institution . . . with [his] diploma written on [his] back!" Abolitionists frequently silence Douglass's analysis: Collins blocks Douglass's attempt to interpret his own life, directing him to "give us the facts," and "we will take care of the philosophy" (367). We know from outside sources that Douglass in fact did more philosophy in early lecturing than he lets on, further evidence of distancing the individual of *Bondage* from that of *Narrative*.⁵¹ As Gooding-Williams notes, Douglass's writing metaphor accompanies his break with Garrison's hermeneutical approach to narrative evidence.⁵² But anecdotes like these also draw parallels to Douglass's critiques of overseers: abolitionists introduce Douglass "as a 'chattel'—a 'thing'—a piece of southern 'property,'" despite also reducing Douglass from an individual to a prop (366). In the pages before, Douglass invokes the writing metaphor to describe slaveowners' cruelty: in Baltimore, he relates that "the overseer had written his character on the living parchment of most

of [slaves'] backs" (329). Like the overseer, Garrison's colleagues saw Douglass as mere material to be shaped. There was what John Sekora calls an "abolitionist imprint" on Douglass.⁵³ If we take these as motivating concerns for Douglass's political break with Garrison, we see then how slave narrative had too framed Douglass as a text to be analyzed and interpreted by others.

After its publication in 1845, *Narrative* provided a textual supplement to Douglass's politics; he referenced it frequently in lectures till the early 1850s.⁵⁴ For unknown reasons, *Narrative* went out of print in the 1850s and was not republished till 1960.⁵⁵ The context surrounding *Narrative* suggests that Douglass's decision to write *My Bondage and My Freedom* corresponded with both substantive political disagreements and the abolitionists' use of experience and narrative. The autobiography, DeLombard writes, would envision narrators not as witnesses but "autonomous citizens."⁵⁶

The People on Trial

Garrison introduced the Douglass of *Narrative* as a "fugitive slave," fit to write his story of "SLAVERY AS IT IS" (*NF*, 6–7). Ten years on, James McCune Smith introduces the author of *My Bondage and My Freedom* as a "Representative American Man," a man spurned by Garrison and others, for "they did not delve into the mind of a colored man for capacities which the pride of race led them to believe to be restricted to their own Saxon blood" (*MB*, 132). Although Smith compares Douglass to slave narrators before, all of them "banners on the outer wall" of abolitionism, he compares the introspection and style of the present text to the Scottish geologist Hugh Miller's autobiography (125–26). Douglass's second narrative will be different, as Smith concludes with a promise for black agency and inheritance: "I feel joy in introducing to you my brother, who has rent his own bonds . . . I shall place this book in the hands of the only child spared me, bidding him to strive and emulate its noble example. You may do likewise" (137). A result of Douglass's self-making and solidarity with bondsmen, "it is an American book, for Americans, in the fullest sense of the idea." In addition to Smith's introduction, the editor's preface includes a letter from Douglass. This letter, supposedly written at the editor's request for the autobiography, transitions personal narrative from putting "slavery on trial" through popular judgment to an occasion to ask who that people is—what "American" is. The letter not only warrants the book's publication but welcomes the reader's own introspection.

Douglass begins his letter concerned that personal narrative seems to seek "notoriety, for its own sake" (105). The genre may misconstrue critique as requiring the experience of slavery, that the book is to invoke empathy: "I

have often refused to narrate my personal experience in public anti-slavery meetings,” Douglass writes, and “I have never placed my opposition to slavery on a basis so narrow as my own enslavement, but rather upon the indestructible and unchangeable laws of human nature, every one of which is perpetually and flagrantly violated by the slave system.” His advice has been that those “having histories worth the writing” don’t write but “commit such work to hands other than their own” (106). “To write of one’s self” without egotism, Douglass writes, “is a work within the ability of but few.” Douglass doesn’t deny that he’d relied on personal experience before: he had written *Narrative*, lectured on it frequently, and drawn on his history in his journal. But he’s distinguishing his present intentions from his previous use of experience. Before this text, personal narrative (and *Narrative*) was all about slavery and the abolitionist movement, not the slave.

Douglass suggests another use for narrative, as he invokes the motif of “slavery on trial.” Slavery “is now at the bar of public opinion—not only of this country, but of the whole civilized world—for judgment.” Those for slavery “have made for it the usual plea—‘not guilty,’” such that any evidence to the contrary cannot “be innocently withheld.” This is where abolitionists invoke slave narrative to bring slavery to judgment. But Douglass wants to use autobiography differently: “I see, too, that there are special reasons why I should write my own biography, in preference to employing another to do it.” The rhetoric of “slavery on trial” has mischaracterized the means and ends of abolitionism. Underneath this motif is another, more important, object of judgment, not slavery but its subjects: “not only is slavery on trial, but unfortunately, the enslaved people are also on trial.” And they are on trial not as accomplices, but as of their assumed irrelevance to the task of justice: “it is alleged, that they are, naturally, inferior; that they are *so low* in the scale of humanity, and so utterly stupid, that they are unconscious of their wrongs, and do not apprehend their rights.” No perspective is named; these could represent the views of slaveowners or abolitionists. When Douglass defends *The North Star* against abolitionists, later in *Bondage* and mentioned above, he uses almost identical language, his reason “the low estimate” of blacks, “his assumed natural inferiority” (386).

This injunction signifies autobiography’s political role, an inquiry common to democratic theory: not to ask whether slavery contradicts law, but to ask from what people these laws arise. At its surface, Douglass’s book will contradict that the enslaved are incapable of knowing wrong and their rights: he’s not writing autobiography to justify his own political role, but that of the oppressed. Yet notice the force of Douglass’s denunciation. If the people responsible for judgment are wrong about slaves—if they’ve misjudged black agency—then “the people” of antebellum America, with its principles

and roles, is itself wrong. Douglass is staging an indictment from the defendant to the judge: slavery on trial is not “the enslaved on trial,” rather it is the people on trial. Slave narrative relied on the abolitionist’s authorization of ex-slave experience, but Douglass is questioning that relation. By writing an autobiography, Douglass can reflect on the lives of others through his own, and ask that readers do the same. He closes the letter: “looking, then, at your request, from this stand-point, and wishing everything of which you think me capable to go to the benefit of my afflicted people, I part with my doubts and hesitation” (106). From the preface of *My Bondage and My Freedom*, Douglass has put into question the authority that had popularized slave narrative, not simply the abolitionists that published but “the people” that read these works. A new personal narrative wouldn’t reflect a people that was, but authorize a people that could be.

Denunciation in *My Bondage and My Freedom*

My Bondage and My Freedom presents Douglass’s life in two narrative segments. The first twenty-one chapters cover the “Life of a Slave,” and the final four chapters present the “Life of a Freeman.” But the book’s title also indicates the two dimensions of denunciation through which Douglass frames his second story: as a descriptive analysis of the people constituted by antebellum slavery, and an expansive advocacy of practices for solidarity in a broader conception of the people.⁵⁷ The autobiography provides an “untold story,” Priscilla Wald writes, “through which a nation—‘a people’—[speaks] itself into existence.”⁵⁸

The first part of denunciation describes the conditions that constitute slavery’s subjects, a close analysis of what Douglass in the 1850s referred to as “Slave Power.”⁵⁹ Slave Power concerned not simply the top-down domination of slaves, but how slavery created and corrupted the character of even its advocates. In *Bondage*, Douglass illuminates the subjection of slaves, slaveowners, and those around the plantation. The first chapter introduces his hometown Tuckahoe, Maryland, by its origin of a man who “took a hoe”: the “dull, flat, and unthrifty district, or neighborhood, surrounded by a white population of the lowest order, indolent and drunken to a proverb, and among slaves, who seemed to ask, ‘*Oh! what’s the use?*’ every time they lifted a hoe” (*MB*, 139–40). Tuckahoe is no emblem of Thomas Jefferson’s agrarian ideal, but impoverished and born in theft. The patriarchy that conditioned both the Declaration’s and Benjamin Franklin’s rebellious independence is absent here: Douglass does not know who his father is, nor his own age, and fatherhood is “literally abolished in slave law and slave practice” (140). Names are taken from owners, not fathers (often one and the same), and mothers

determine children's age by the harvest seasons (151, 140). Denunciation outlines the plantation as "a little nation of its own, having its own language, its own rules, regulations and customs," all of which influence the identities of both slaves and slaveowners (160).

The second part of denunciation expands the reader's view of the people by narrating Douglass's self-making through acts of independent *and* interdependent emancipation, similar to what Gooding-Williams calls Douglass's "plantation politics."⁶⁰ Throughout the autobiography, Douglass invokes Lord Byron's "Hereditary bondsmen, know ye not // Who would be free, themselves must strike the blow?" (*MB*, 287). As an address to those in chains, "hereditary bondsmen" casts those men as Douglass's alienated family; framed as an inquiry, the address invites those bondsmen to reply. Self-making is not strictly individualist: the autobiography forecasts Douglass's "Self-Made Men," first presented in 1859, saying there that "I believe in individuality, but individuals are, to the mass, like waves to the ocean."⁶¹ In speeches like these and the 1848 "What Are the Colored People Doing for Themselves?" Douglass demonstrates what Waldo Martin calls "the inevitability and necessity of human interdependence" and what Jack Turner has recently theorized as Douglass's "democratic egalitarian obligation": the communal activities that ground self-reliance.⁶² As Turner observes in Douglass's later politics, *Bondage*'s denunciation promotes solidarity not only with bondsmen but white dissenters on and off the plantation. As in his description of slavery, Douglass explains these expansive practices such that a white reader might approach *Bondage* differently than he had *Narrative*.

In order to explore how *Bondage* remakes Douglass through denunciation, we can look at the book's invocation of three conceptual areas of self-authorization resonant in early American political thought and autobiography: education, resistance, and labor.

Education on Douglass's plantation is limited for the slaveowner as well as the slave. No schoolhouse exists in these communities: visiting teachers tutor the slaveowners' children (*MB*, 158). The control of knowledge on the plantation, much like the politics surrounding slave narrative, veils both sides: "ignorance is a high virtue in a human chattel; and as the master studies to keep the slave ignorant, the slave is cunning enough to make the master think he succeeds" (172). Douglass realizes this when asking his mistress Mrs. Auld to teach him to read. Overheard by her husband, Hugh chides her that reading "would forever unfit [Douglass] for the duties of a slave" (217). The slave's only education is to work, not think. Though this scene appears in *Narrative*, unique to *Bondage* is the slaveowner's subjection: Douglass describes how Hugh's forbiddance corrupts Sophia's character. She twists to see Douglass not as family but property: "we were both victims to the same

overshadowing evil—*she*, as mistress, *I*, as slave” (227). This scene contains Douglass’s early awareness of race; he notes in Hugh’s preemption “the *white* man’s power to perpetuate the enslavement of the *black* man.” Knowledge for the slaveowner isn’t a pathway to truth, but a way to racialize the power disparity between slave and master.

By recognizing the span of plantation ignorance, Douglass glimpses the possibility of emancipation. Later as a shipyard apprentice, he explains that

to make a contented slave, you must make a thoughtless one. It is necessary to darken his moral and mental vision, and, as far as possible, to annihilate his power of reason. He must be able to detect no inconsistencies in slavery. The man that takes his earnings, must be able to convince him that he has a perfect right to do so. It must not depend upon mere force: the slave must know no Higher Law than his master’s will. The whole relationship must not only demonstrate, to his mind, its necessity, but its absolute rightfulness. If there be one crevice through which a single drop can fall, it will certainly rust off the slave’s chain. (337)

Intellectual resistance begins with “a single drop.” Douglass’s first act is his secretly reading *The Columbian Orator*’s story of a slave and his master debating slavery, the slave’s argument winning his manumission (225). Education requires Douglass to be both educated and educator. Shortly after, he converts to Methodism and learns the bible from a local black man named Lawson, whom in turn Douglass teaches to read (232). In Baltimore, young white boys help Douglass learn to write; upon leaving, Douglass pledges new community with “those to whom I *imparted* instruction, and to those little white boys from whom I *received* instruction” (235, 243). Just as ignorance implicates his holders, emancipation implicates whites while building black solidarity. Once at St. Michael’s to work under Thomas Auld, Douglass begins a Sabbath school with the assistance of a young white man, which Auld soon interrupts (254). Another attempted school while at Mr. Freeland’s farm results in “an attachment, deep and lasting,” Douglass writes, that “sprung up between me and my persecuted pupils” (300). Every scene of education past the *Orator* advocates the collective education of clandestine pupils, leaving room for white aid without undermining black agency.

Scenes of violence provide further opportunity for denunciation: as Douglass had written in 1854 on slave kidnapping, “resistance is . . . wise as well as just.”⁶³ Violence is everywhere in *Bondage*. After witnessing Esther’s beating for courting another slave, Douglass is “hushed, terrified, stunned” that “the fate of Esther might be mine next” (*MB*, 175). Force establishes hierarchy: every member of the plantation “wants the privilege of whipping somebody else” (165). Violence is systemic and not innate in the overseer,

“part of the system, rather than a part of the man” (174). He acts on “motives of policy, rather than from a hardened nature.” These structures reach beyond the plantation to local governance. Douglass recalls the overseer Gore’s shooting of the resistant slave Denby: the law leaves Gore unindicted, yet he defends the shooting as his “duty” (201). Yet the Douglass of *Bondage* often cautions the slaveowner as himself a likely victim of the system, he who “never lisps a syllable in commendation of the fathers of this republic, nor denounces any attempted oppression of himself, without inviting the knife to his own throat, and asserting the rights of rebellion for his own slaves” (302). As in passages on education, Douglass invokes American themes of self-authorization (like the right of rebellion) to critique slavery.

Few scenes capture Douglass’s self-making like his work on the land of “Covey the Negro breaker.” His owner Thomas Auld sends the young man to Edward Covey’s to be broken, the slave-breaker no mere man but an institution: he provides slaveowners a fast track for slave subjection (256). Covey’s notoriety slows Douglass’s pace on the way, Douglass “to be broken to the yoke of a bitter and life-long bondage” (259). Once there, Covey subjects Douglass to conditions that emphasize slavery as producing not goods but the slave subject: when asked to retrieve wood using two oxen (themselves unbroken), Douglass recalls the task as unproductive (261). A year into his stay, an opportunity arises. Douglass briefly escapes to beg of Auld’s sympathy, who sends him back (276). Though Douglass returns unmolested, soon the breaker springs at Douglass to subdue him. Both men are caught off-guard by the slave’s response: “my resistance was entirely unexpected,” yet “*I was resolved to fight*” (283). Douglass’s fight stages the meeting of subjection with agency, the two eye-to-eye. “At the moment, as though we stood as equals before the law,” Douglass recalls, “the very color of man was forgotten.” They are matched: “he held me, and I held him.”

Though this scene features prominently in *Narrative*, Douglass’s emphasis on communal resistance in *Bondage* is unique. During the two-hour struggle, Covey appeals to and is rejected by three others, each of whom represent different authorities within a slave economy. Covey’s cousin Hughes shies away when Douglass delivers him a “kick which sent him staggering away in pain” (284). Covey yells for the hired man Bill, who insists that his job isn’t the beating of slaves (285). Finally, Covey calls his slave Caroline, who won’t respond; in an earlier chapter Douglass introduces Caroline as Covey’s so-called “breeder” (267). Covey’s attempt to break Douglass is refused by family, employee, and property, all relations protected by Slave Power. Those once complicit in breaking now turn away, Douglass writing that “we were all in open rebellion, that morning” (285). Recalling this scene, Herbert Marcuse recounted to Angela Davis what she and Douglass taught him, that “freedom is not only the goal of liberation, it *begins* with liberation.”⁶⁴

Throughout the book, Douglass forms his “band of brothers,” the men with whom he plans to escape (*MB*, 320). Though he never sponsors insurrection, *Bondage* depicts Douglass’s plantation fellows as “revolutionary conspirators” (309). Douglass calls his community at Freeland’s farm “a unit”: “thoughts and sentiments were exchanged between us, which might well be called very incendiary . . . by oppressors and tyrants” (301). He is a leader among men, but he takes responsibility rather than credit. When his band fails to escape, Douglass insists, “if any one is to blame for disturbing the quiet of the slaves and slave-masters of the neighborhood of St. Michael’s, *I am the man*” (309). Caught by holders, Douglass is disappointed not for his likely removal to Alabama, but that he is now “solitary in the world” (324). To respond to the violence that constitutes slavery’s subjects requires new solidarity.

Finally, we return to the property inequality upon which Tuckahoe was founded. Having escaped in 1841, Douglass did not buy his legal freedom till two years after he published *Narrative* (*MB*, 376). In 1850 the Fugitive Slave Law reaffirmed the legal status of the slave as property, a law (as Douglass lectured in 1852) that reduced the slave below a “jackass,” since only the removal of the latter required a jury.⁶⁵ By 1855, the legal status of both Douglass and black Americans had changed. In *Bondage*, Douglass explains how slavery corrupts property for all participants. The plantation treats the slave like livestock, evident in Covey’s pairing the ‘unbroken’ Douglass with ‘unbroken’ oxen, or in the auction to divide slaves after Douglass’s master dies: “personality swallowed up in the sordid idea of property! Manhood lost in chattelhood!” (*MB*, 237). Slave children sleep in beds with no blankets, and eat cornmeal mush “like so many pigs” (208). Again, this touches the slaveowner’s character: Sophia Auld’s disapproval of Douglass’s reading requires “some training,” to forget Douglass’s “human nature and character” (221). Even when slaveowners provide slaves some autonomy, Douglass is a machine rather than man. When he’s beaten while apprenticing in the Baltimore shipyard, Hugh Auld is infuriated only by the assailants’ disregard for his “rights of property” in Douglass (334).

Douglass observes that human chattelhood not only treats slaves as animals, but distorts slaveowners’ entire relation to labor. Trying to understand the slaveowner’s accusations of slaves’ laziness, Douglass pins it on owners cultivating “such an intense dread of labor” that they refuse to work but through the slave (276). For Master Thomas to assume Douglass’s languor reflects not slave behavior but the institution’s influence on Thomas: “he probably thought that were *he* in the place of a slave—with no wages for his work, no praise for well doing, no motive for toil but the lash—he would try every possible scheme by which to escape labor.” The Lockean ethos that

connects individuality to labor is absent on the plantation, and thus the slaveowner is equally dependent on the slave. His identity requires he work only through slaves. Although Douglass's observation focuses on the plantation, it resembles those that Abraham Lincoln had made against the Kansas-Nebraska Act just one year prior, that nationwide slavery sapped the land's potential for the agrarian ideal: for blacks as well as whites.⁶⁶

Emancipation from this alienation requires Douglass to subvert and oppose the system. He justifies stealing food from Thomas Auld as "a question of *removal*—the taking his meat out of one tub, and putting it into another; the ownership of the meat was not affected by the transaction" (*MB*, 247). If human beings *are* property, then a *right* of property is nonsensical. "Since each slave belongs to all: all must, therefore, belong to each," Douglass declares, the plantation having "no conflicting rights of property" (247–48, 160). Real freedom, however, requires that Douglass learn a trade. Apprenticing at a shipyard while living with Hugh Auld, Douglass begins leasing out his skills (336–37). He asks, "why should I be a slave?": "I contracted for it, worked for it, earned it, collected it; it was paid to me, and it was *rightfully* my own." With this trade comes Douglass's increased awareness of oppression, the affirmation of his own acquisitive capacity, and further opportunities to resist Hugh by embezzling earnings in preparation for escape (343). Yet again, these acts complement the need for community among those oppressed. In the shipyard, Douglass notes a lack of workers' awareness of the conflict between slavery and "the interests of the white mechanics and laborers of the south" (329–30). Douglass predicts the "overthrow" of slavery following these workers' consciousness, despite racial animosity between whites and blacks. Every scene of self-making in *My Bondage and My Freedom* is preceded by an analysis of the plantation, and succeeded by a call to awakening and solidarity. This is to denounce wrongs through autobiography.

Conclusion: The Politics of Autobiography

Between his two narratives, Douglass published his only piece of fiction, the 1853 novella "The Heroic Slave." An embellished account of an ex-slave rebel and mutineer's true story, the tale begins with a white traveler overhearing the slave's soliloquized "What is freedom to me, or I to it?"⁶⁷ The slave's pronounced "I shall be free" moves the eavesdropper, who "long desired to sound the mysterious depths of the thoughts and feelings of a slave." The slave finishes with "scathing denunciations of the cruelty and injustice of slavery" and leaves. The listener (aptly "Mr. Listwell") stands for his own soliloquy in reverence of things overheard, concluding that "from this hour I

am abolitionist.” Despite their separation, the black claimant converts the white onlooker through his self-affirmation.

To denounce wrong is not to retire subjective accounts of injustice, rather it stages dissent *through* self-analysis. *My Bondage and My Freedom* is an answer to what Douglass had asked his audience on July 5th, 1852: “Fellow-citizens, pardon me, allow me to ask, why am I called upon to speak here to-day? What have I, or those I represent, to do with your national independence?”⁶⁸ Douglass finds his autobiographical identity through structures that implicate not only other slaves but those in and around plantation society. Thus Douglass authorizes himself twice: as an author he philosophizes on slavery and its subjects in ways prohibited by *Narrative* and the early abolitionists, and as a narrated protagonist he emancipates himself in solidarity with others. Both dimensions of denunciation, then—analysis and advocacy—implicate other Americans. Whereas *Narrative* asked its reader only to confirm Douglass’s tale and its correspondence to Garrison’s politics, Douglass concludes *Bondage* committed to the “universal and unconditional emancipation of my entire race” (*MB*, 398). As Wilson Jeremiah Moses and others have pointed out, Douglass is inconsistent on the question of race throughout his life, his thoughts fluctuating through the Civil War and Reconstruction.⁶⁹ Yet *Bondage* reveals Douglass to be increasingly aware of the racial inequality that will linger beyond slavery, and so he balances the call to black solidarity with the invocation of white readers as well. Everything is bigger in *Bondage*: the stakes higher, the critiques expanded, the advocacy more ambitious. Douglass achieves this not through simply narrating his disagreements with Garrison in the final pages, but through a new story of self-making inspired by those disagreements.

My Bondage and My Freedom is an autobiography for the people. Readers find in it not an account of what one man was but who the people could be. The autobiography recalls not “the dead form of the Union,” but “the living present,” just as Douglass read the Constitution in response to the 1857 *Dred Scott v. Sandford*: “‘We, the people’—not we, the white people—not we, the citizens, or the legal voters – not we, the privileged class . . . but we the people—the men and women, the human inhabitants of the United States.”⁷⁰ We might say that denunciation provides an altered form of Stanley Cavell’s claim to community. Whereas for Cavell a failure of “we say” may imply that “there is no us (yet, maybe never) to say anything about,” Douglass leaves this abandonment to Garrison’s disunion politics, Douglass in favor of a more perfect union.⁷¹ For Douglass, denouncing is to search for what we *can* say of us, to make way for the announcement of some new people and popular response to slavery and racial injustice.

In closing, I want to suggest that *My Bondage and My Freedom* is an inaugural entry in an American tradition of political autobiography. Angela Davis offered reasons for writing her 1974 autobiography when she was just twenty-eight, reasons that echo Douglass's over a century before:

I knew that my potential as an autobiographical subject was created by the massive global movement that successfully achieved my freedom. So the question was how to write an autobiography that would be attentive to this community of collective struggle. I did not want to write a conventional autobiography in which the heroic subject offers lessons to readers. I decided that I would write a political autobiography exploring the ways in which I had been shaped by movements and campaigns in communities of struggle.⁷²

A political autobiography seeks to authorize its author through the call for a new people. It configures itself one among many oriented against a present state formation, a present sense of the people insufficiently attuned to injustice. It's to this tradition that Washington and Du Bois looked in vying for Douglass's legacy. In different registers, both *Walden* and *The Education of Henry Adams* too sought to contend state imperialism and industrialization through autobiography. In the 1970s, not only would Davis publish her political autobiography, but second-wave feminism would find new material for consciousness-raising groups and women's history courses in Goldman's *Living My Life*. Douglass's denunciation in *My Bondage and My Freedom*, like Madison Washington's soliloquy, sought to refound the nation as it remade its speaker, in a genre that was anything but individual.

Acknowledgments

I'd like to thank Tom Balcerski, Alex Black, Jill Spivey Caddell, Tom Dumm, Kevin Duong, Clement Fatovic, Jason Frank, Aaron Gavin, Michael Gorup, Desmond Jagmohan, Isaac Kramnick, Alex Livingston, Chris Lynch, Inder Marwah, Will Pennington, Vijay Phulwani, Diane Rubenstein, Shirley Samuels, Bécquer Seguin, Avery Slater, and Anna Marie Smith, as well as anonymous reviewers and the editors of *Political Theory*, for productive feedback on various versions of the article.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The author(s) received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Notes

1. Frederick Douglass, "My Bondage and My Freedom," in *Autobiographies* (New York: Library of America, 1994), 367. Future citations in-text as (*MB*, #).
2. See John W. Blassingame, "Introduction to Volume One," in Frederick Douglass, *The Frederick Douglass Papers. Vol. 1, Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave*, ed. John R. McKivigan, Peter P. Hinks, and John W. Blassingame, Series Two: Autobiographical Writings (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1999), xxxii.
3. See *ibid.*, xxi.
4. "Frederick Douglass to Thomas Auld, Rochester, [N.Y.] 8 September 1848," in *The Frederick Douglass Papers. Vol. 1, 1842-1852*, ed. John R. McKivigan, Series Three: Correspondence (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1999), 315.
5. See Waldo E. Martin, *The Mind of Frederick Douglass* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1984), 31.
6. On Douglass's relationship with other leaders, see Robert S. Levine, *Martin Delany, Frederick Douglass, and the Politics of Representative Identity* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1997); John Stauffer, *The Black Hearts of Men: Radical Abolitionists and the Transformation of Race* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002).
7. David W. Blight, *Frederick Douglass' Civil War: Keeping Faith in Jubilee* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1989), 12.
8. See Blassingame, "Introduction to Volume One," xxxii.
9. I do not comment on *Life and Times* here, primarily due to my focus on Douglass's antebellum years and also due to the relevant unpopularity of the last book's first publication: in its first seven years it only sold a paltry 463 copies. That said, there is much to be mined in placing that text alongside Douglass's others or those of contemporaries Booker T. Washington and W.E.B. Du Bois. On the book's sales, see William L. Andrews, "Introduction," in *Critical Essays on Frederick Douglass*, ed. William L. Andrews (Boston: G.K. Hall, 1991), 5.
10. See Frederick Douglass, *The Frederick Douglass Papers. Vol. 2, My Bondage and My Freedom*, ed. John W. Blassingame, John R. McKivigan, and Peter P. Hinks, Series Two: Autobiographical Writings (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1999), 431.
11. W.E.B. Du Bois, *The Souls of Black Folk* (New York: Bantam Classics, 1989), 37; Eric J. Sundquist, *To Wake the Nations: Race in the Making of American Literature* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1993), 86.
12. See Peter C. Myers, *Frederick Douglass: Race and the Rebirth of American Liberalism* (Lawrence: University Press of Kansas, 2008); Nicholas Buccola, *The Political Thought of Frederick Douglass: In Pursuit of American Liberty* (New York: New York University Press, 2012).
13. See Herbert Marcuse, "Dear Angela," *Ramparts*, February 1971; Sharon R. Krause, *Liberalism with Honor* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002), chap. 5; Nick Bromell, "Democratic Indignation: Black American Thought and the Politics of Dignity," *Political Theory* 41, no. 2 (2013): 285–311.

14. For recent theory on these topics, see Joel Alden Schlosser, "Socrates in a Different Key: James Baldwin and Race in America," *Political Research Quarterly* 66, no. 3 (2013): 487–99; George M. Shulman, *American Prophecy: Race and Redemption in American Political Culture* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2008); Stephen Marshall, *The City on the Hill from Below: The Crisis of Prophetic Black Politics* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 2011); Melvin L. Rogers, "David Walker and the Political Power of the Appeal," *Political Theory*, March 12, 2014. The best examples of a political theory approach to autobiography include Philip Abbott, *States of Perfect Freedom: Autobiography and American Political Thought* (Amherst: University of Massachusetts Press, 1987); Kenneth Mostern, *Autobiography and Black Identity Politics: Racialization in Twentieth-Century America* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999); Katharine Lawrence Balfour, *Democracy's Reconstruction: Thinking Politically with W.E.B. Du Bois* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011), chap. 4; Robert Gooding-Williams, *In the Shadow of Du Bois: Afro-Modern Political Thought in America* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2009), chap. 5.
15. Gooding-Williams, *Shadow of Du Bois*, 168.
16. Although I clarify the stakes of this distinction below, I should note that there is debate over whether slave narrative constitutes autobiography, and where Douglass's *Narrative* fits. I side with James Olney, who argues that the author's purely historical relation to experience in slave narrative distinguishes it from the creative self-fashioning of autobiography. See James Olney, "'I Was Born': Slave Narratives, Their Status as Autobiography and as Literature," in *The Slave's Narrative*, ed. Charles T. Davis and Henry Louis Gates, Jr. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1985), 151. For more on this debate, see John Sekora, "'Mr. Editor, If You Please': Frederick Douglass, *My Bondage and My Freedom*, and the End of the Abolitionist Imprint," *Callaloo* 17, no. 2 (1994): 608–26; Robert B. Stepto, *From Behind the Veil: A Study of Afro-American Narrative* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1991); Robert Levine, "The Slave Narrative and the Revolutionary Tradition of American Autobiography," in *The Cambridge Companion to the African American Slave Narrative*, ed. Audrey A. Fisch (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 99–101.
17. Orlando Patterson, *Slavery and Social Death: A Comparative Study* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982).
18. Melvin L. Rogers, "The People, Rhetoric, and Affect: On the Political Force of Du Bois's *The Souls of Black Folk*," *American Political Science Review* 106, no. 1 (2012): 188.
19. *Ibid.*, 194.
20. See Jason A. Frank, *Constituent Moments: Enacting the People in Postrevolutionary America* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2010).
21. Paul de Man, "Autobiography as De-Facement," *Mln* 94, no. 5 (1979): 921; Julie Rak, *Negotiated Memory: Doukhobor Autobiographical Discourse* (Vancouver, Canada: University of British Columbia Press, 2004), ix. On the history of the

- genre, see Sidonie Smith and Julia Watson, *Reading Autobiography: A Guide for Interpreting Life Narratives* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2010), 193–211.
22. Irving Howe, *Politics and the Novel* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1957), 16.
 23. See Myers, *Frederick Douglass*; Buccola, *Frederick Douglass*; Charles W. Mills, *Blackness Visible: Essays on Philosophy and Race* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1998).
 24. On the former, see Gooding-Williams, *Shadow of Du Bois*, chap. 5. On the latter, see Nick Bromell, “A ‘Voice from the Enslaved’: The Origins of Frederick Douglass’s Political Philosophy of Democracy,” *American Literary History* 23, no. 4 (2011): 697–723; Jack Turner, *Awakening to Race: Individualism and Social Consciousness in America* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012), chap. 3.
 25. Michael Hanchard, “Contours of Black Political Thought: An Introduction and Perspective,” *Political Theory* 38, no. 4 (2010): 512.
 26. Sheldon S. Wolin, “The Liberal/Democratic Divide. On Rawls’s *Political Liberalism*,” *Political Theory* 24, no. 1 (1996): 98.
 27. Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Confessions*, trans. J. M. Cohen (London: Penguin, 1981), 17.
 28. See William L. Andrews, *To Tell a Free Story: The First Century of Afro-American Autobiography, 1760-1865* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1986), 6.
 29. See *ibid.*, 65.
 30. See Blassingame, “Introduction to Volume One,” xxvi–xxvii.
 31. See Andrews, *To Tell*, 33–35. See also John Sekora, “Black Message/White Envelope: Genre, Authenticity, and Authority in the Antebellum Slave Narrative,” *Callaloo*, no. 32 (1987): 482–515.
 32. See Blassingame, “Introduction to Volume One,” xxiv.
 33. Jeannine Marie DeLombard, *Slavery on Trial: Law, Abolitionism, and Print Culture* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2007), 1.
 34. See *ibid.*, 109.
 35. Houston A. Baker Jr., “Autobiographical Acts and the Voice of the Southern Slave,” in *Critical Essays on Frederick Douglass*, ed. William L. Andrews, 94. Slave narratives were “an act or process of simultaneous self-creation and self-emancipation.” Paul Gilroy, *The Black Atlantic: Modernity and Double Consciousness* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1993), 69.
 36. See Elizabeth McHenry, *Forgotten Readers: Recovering the Lost History of African-American Literary Societies* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2002), 13.
 37. Kristie Dotson, “A Cautionary Tale: On Limiting Epistemic Oppression,” *Frontiers: A Journal of Women Studies* 33, no. 1 (2012): 24.
 38. Frederick Douglass, “I Have Come to Tell You Something about Slavery: An Address Delivered in Lynn, Massachusetts, in October 1841,” in *The Frederick*

- Douglass Papers. Vol. 1, 1841-1846*, ed. John W. Blassingame and John R. McKivigan, Series One: Speeches, Debates, and Interviews (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1979), 3.
39. See Martin, *Frederick Douglass*, 25.
 40. See "Frederick Douglass to William Lloyd Garrison, Perth, Scot. 27 Jan[uary] 1846," in *The Frederick Douglass Papers. Vol. 1, 1842-1852*, ed. John R. McKivigan, Series Three: Correspondence (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1999), 81-88.
 41. Philippe Lejeune, "The Autobiographical Pact," in *On Autobiography*, trans. Paul John Eakin (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1989), 3-30.
 42. Frederick Douglass, "Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, An American Slave," in *Autobiographies* (New York: Library of America, 1994), 2. Future citations in-text as (*NF*, #).
 43. On moral suasion and slave narrative, see Dickson D. Bruce, "Politics and Political Philosophy in the Slave Narrative," in *The Cambridge Companion to the African American Slave Narrative*, ed. Audrey A. Fisch (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 30.
 44. Margaret Fuller, "[Review of *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, An American Slave*]," in *Critical Essays on Frederick Douglass*, ed. William L. Andrews, 21-22.
 45. Joan W. Scott, "The Evidence of Experience," *Critical Inquiry* 17, no. 4 (1991): 778.
 46. *Ibid.*, 779.
 47. Ephraim Peabody, "Narratives of Fugitive Slaves," in *Critical Essays on Frederick Douglass*, ed. William L. Andrews, 25.
 48. Quoted in Blassingame, "Introduction to Volume One," xlv.
 49. On the abolitionists' use of the printing press, see Robert Fanuzzi, *Abolition's Public Sphere* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2003).
 50. Michael Warner, *The Letters of the Republic: Publication and the Public Sphere in Eighteenth-Century America* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1990), 74.
 51. See DeLombard, *Slavery on Trial*, 102.
 52. Gooding-Williams, *Shadow of Du Bois*, 199.
 53. Sekora, "Black Message," 497.
 54. See Blassingame, "Introduction to Volume One," xxxii.
 55. See John Stauffer, "Frederick Douglass's Self-Fashioning and the Making of a Representative American Man," in *The Cambridge Companion to the African American Slave Narrative*, ed. Audrey A. Fisch (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 207.
 56. DeLombard, *Slavery on Trial*, 105.
 57. My reading of *Bondage* is greatly indebted to the scholarship of Sundquist, Andrews, and Gooding-Williams, all of whom emphasize the communal politics unique to the second autobiography. My account is distinct in setting out to elucidate denunciation, and to contrast its motifs of self-making against the context

- of *Narrative* and American political thought writ large. See Gooding-Williams, *Shadow of Du Bois*, chap. 5; Andrews, *To Tell*, chap. 6; Sundquist, *To Wake the Nations*, chap. 1.
58. Priscilla Wald, *Constituting Americans: Cultural Anxiety and Narrative Form*, 2nd ed. (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1995), 2.
 59. See Blight, *Douglass' Civil War*, 40.
 60. Gooding-Williams, *Shadow of Du Bois*, 183–184.
 61. Frederick Douglass, “Self-Made Men,” in *The Frederick Douglass Papers. Vol. 5, 1881–1895*, ed. John W. Blassingame and John R. McKivigan, Series One: Speeches, Debates, and Interviews (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1979), 549.
 62. Martin, *Frederick Douglass*, 257; Turner, *Awakening to Race*, 47.
 63. Frederick Douglass, “Is It Right and Wise to Kill a Kidnapper?,” in *The Life and Writings of Frederick Douglass. Vol. 2, Pre-Civil War Decade, 1850–1860*, ed. Philip Sheldon Foner (New York: International Publishers, 1950), 287.
 64. Marcuse, “Dear Angela.”
 65. Frederick Douglass, “The Fugitive Slave Law, Speech to the National Free Soil Convention at Pittsburgh, August 11, 1852,” in *Frederick Douglass: Selected Speeches and Writings*, ed. Philip Sheldon Foner (Chicago: Lawrence Hill Books, 1999), 208. On slavery’s property laws, see Stephen M. Best, *The Fugitive’s Properties: Law and the Poetics of Possession* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2004).
 66. Abraham Lincoln, “Speech on the Kansas-Nebraska Act at Peoria, Illinois,” in *Abraham Lincoln: Selected Speeches and Writings*, ed. Gore Vidal (New York: Library of America, 2009), 93–99.
 67. Frederick Douglass, “The Heroic Slave,” in *Three Classic African-American Novels*, ed. William L. Andrews (New York: Mentor, 1990), 27–30.
 68. Frederick Douglass, “What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?: An Address Delivered in Rochester, New York, on 5 July 1852,” in *The Frederick Douglass Papers. Vol. 2, 1847–1854*, ed. John W. Blassingame and John R. McKivigan, Series One: Speeches, Debates, and Interviews (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1979), 367. Douglass included an extract of this speech in the appendix for *Bondage*.
 69. Wilson Jeremiah Moses, *Creative Conflict in African American Thought: Frederick Douglass, Alexander Crummell, Booker T. Washington, W.E.B. Du Bois, and Marcus Garvey* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 6.
 70. Frederick Douglass, “The Dred Scott Decision: An Address Delivered, in Part, in New York, New York, in May 1857,” in *The Frederick Douglass Papers. Vol. 3, 1855–1863*, ed. John W. Blassingame and John R. McKivigan, Series One: Speeches, Debates, and Interviews (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1979), 172, 176.
 71. Stanley Cavell, *The Claim of Reason: Wittgenstein, Skepticism, Morality, and Tragedy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999), 20.
 72. Angela Y. Davis, *Abolition Democracy: Beyond Empire, Prisons, and Torture* (New York: Seven Stories Press, 2005), 17.

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